

READING SKILLS

Reading Comprehension

Reading, like any other, skill, needs to be practised regularly. In order to read fast with accuracy (i.e. to read the text with speed without missing any important points), the following points should be kept in mind :

1. Concentrate on the text.
2. Do not have backward eye movement (regress) to read the same words or phrases again. It lowers the speed of reading.
3. Make proper sense groups otherwise you might miss the real meaning.
4. If you do not know the meaning of a certain word, do not get disappointed. Try to guess the meaning from the surrounding sentences.
5. Try to predict what you are going to read after reading one or two sentences.
6. Read the questions carefully and answer them in your own words.

(a) Prose Passages

A. Read the passage and answer the questions:

During the winter of 1945 I lived for several months in a house in Brooklyn. It was not a shabby place, but a pleasantly furnished one. It was well kept by its owners- two elderly sisters. Mr. Jones lived in the room next to mine. My room was the smallest in the house, his the largest, a nice big sunshiny room, which Mr. Jones never left. All his needs- meal, shopping, laundry- were attended to by the middle-aged landladies. Also, he was not without visitors; on an average, half-dozen various persons, men and women, young and old, in-between visited him from early morning till late in the evening. He was not a drug dealer or a fortune teller; no, they just came to talk to him and apparently they made him small gifts of money for his conversation and advice. If not, he had no obvious means of support. I never had a conversation with him because I was out most of the time. He was a handsome man about forty; slender, black-haired and with distinctive face; a pale, lean face, high cheek bones, and with a birthmark on his left cheek. He wore gold-rimmed glasses with black lenses, for he was blind and cripple too. He was always dressed in pressed dark grey or blue three-piece suit and a light coloured tie-as though he was set off for work.

1. Circle the correct answer:
 - (i) Mr. Jones earned his living by
 - (a) selling drugs

- (b) telling future
- (c) giving advice to people
- (ii) Mr. Jones was looked after by
 - (a) the landladies
 - (b) the visitors
 - (c) the author
- (iii) _____ came to visit Mr. Jones.
 - (a) old people
 - (b) young people
 - (c) people of all ages
- 2. What did the landladies do for Mr. Jones?
- 3. Write the words in the brackets which in the passage mean :
 - (a) not in a good condition ()
 - (b) easy to understand ()
 - (c) thin and attractive ()
- 4. Describe Mr. Jones in not more than five sentences.

B. Read the passage carefully and answer the questions:

Yehudi Menuhin moved from Highgate into his early 19th century house in London's Belgravia last July but has only lived in it for a couple of months. Born in 1917, the famous violinist and conductor, who first began his public career at the age of seven in San Francisco, still spends nine months of the year on tour. His room is four storeys up on the top floor and a lift was waiting for us in the front hall. His wife greets us and we find the maestro waiting for us on the landing.

He leads the way up a further flight of polished wooden stairs to his studio. 'This is my room and I absolutely love it.' The idea is that the studio look like a ship. Its walls are covered with pinewood and natural light comes in through the windows in the roof. On the floor there are cotton rugs which were made in central Asia. The whole of one wall is covered with letters in frames, paintings and prints, mostly collected by his wife Diana. 'Anything I have of beauty or value was given to me by my wife, including herself'. He doesn't like empty surfaces. 'I need many tables.' The card table proves his point, with its neat rows of objects standing around a figure that was found in the Athens antique market. The grand piano belonged to Menuhin's mother-in law, who was a brilliant pianist. Rows of photographs are displayed on top. An Indian string instrument lying by the window contrasts with the record player and tape deck nearby.

- 1. Where does Yehudi Menuhin live?
- 2. What instrument does he play?
- 3. When did he perform for the public for the first time?

4. Circle the correct answer:
Yehudi Menuhin's first performance was in:
(a) San Francisco
(b) London
(c) Athens
5. Does he live in his home-town through out the year?
6. Briefly describe Yehudi Menuhin's studio. (3-4 sentences only)

C. Read the passage given below and answer the questions:

What kind of a car will be driving in 2010? Rather different from the type we know today, with the next 20 years bringing greater change than the past 50. The people who will be designing the models of tomorrow, believe that enviornmental problems may well accelerate the pace of the car's development. Today they are students of the transport design course at London's Royal College of Art.

Their vision is of a machine with three wheels instead of four, electrically powered, environmentally clean, and able to drive itself along 'intelligent' roads with built-in power supplies. Future cars will pick up their fuel during long journeys from a power source built into the road, or store it in small quantities for travelling in the city. Instead of today's seating arrangements- two in front, two or three behind, all facing forward-the 2010 car will have a different design with adults and children sitting in a family circle.

This view of the future car is based on a much more sophisticated road system, with strips built into motorways to supply power to vehicles pasing along them. Cars will not need drivers, because computers will provide safe driving control and route finding. All the driver will have to do is, say where to go and the computer will do the rest. It will become impossible for the cars to crash into one another. The technology already exists for the car to become a true automobile.

1. Why will the new cars be developed?
2. Who is going to develop them?
3. How will the future cars be different from the present ones?
4. Why will the future cars have different seating arrangement? Will the new seating arrangement be safe? How?
5. Complete the following statements:
(a) The driving will become safer and easier because _____
(b) The future cars will leave the environment clean because _____
6. Write 3-4 sentences about the future car.

D. Read the following passage and answer the questions:

Tokyo is an ugly city. There are hardly any beautiful or even good buildings; there are very few parks; there are no mountains or even hills inside or outside the city; there is no green

belt; there are few monuments worth looking at; the air pollution is terrifying; the perpetual noise deafening; the traffic murderous.

But not all is ugliness in Tokyo. There are a few good buildings and impressive temples and shrines; there are a few park worth visiting. And the overcrowding, the lack of space, has one advantage, pleasing at least to the eye. Everything has to be small in Tokyo; houses, rooms, shops-even, one feels, people, to fit into the small houses. Long side-streets consists of tiny houses only, and this often creates a toy-like, unreal quality, with small women tip-toeing along in their *kimonos* and equally small men sitting, motionless, inside their tiny shops.

Tokyo at night is very different place from Tokyo in daytime. After the offices have closed and commuters have left the town, Tokyo puts on a new face. Millions of neon signs are switched on. The cafes, bars and nightclubs, *sushi-places*, *yakitoriya*, Chinese restaurants and theatres, cinemas and many other places. This wild, high and mondaine nightlife goes on and on and on- until 10.30 at night. Some nightclubs stay open till much later. By 11 p.m. (earlier on Sundays) all the gaiety is over, everyone is at home and in bed.

A town is not its buildings alone; it is an atmosphere, its ambience, its feel, its pleasures, its sadness, its madness, its disappointments and above all its people. Tokyo may lack architectural beauty but it has character and excitement; it is alive. I found it a mysterious and lovable city.

1. Is Tokyo environment friendly? Mention at least three characteristics that go against Tokyo.
2. Is Tokyo different at night? How?
3. What makes the city pleasant?
4. Does the author like the city? How does he describe it?
5. Write the words in the brackets which in the passage mean :
 - (a) gives satisfaction ()
 - (b) atmosphere ()

E. Read the passage given below and answer the questions:

Even after three decades, the memory of that September afternoon is still fresh. It started and ended in a few seconds; but the disappointment haunts me till the day. The toil, the tension, the torment, I've lived with them all. Today when I recall those moments, my heart bleeds. Isn't it ironical that the best chapter of one's life should end in pain for me. The pain is more than words can ever describe.

Missing an Olympic medal by a whisker caused me more disappointment than the happiness which I expressed after winning the medals in the Asian Games and from my winning sequence all over the Europe. Looking back I would say it was a matter of luck. I am sure Ron Clarke would agree with that. The great middle-distance runner set 17 world records but could not win an Olympic gold. Even to this day, I regret not having entered the 200 metre race, where I could have figured among the medal winners. There is no question about it.

1. What disappointment does Milkha Singh talk about?
2. Why does his heart bleed?
3. Why does Milkha Singh mention Ron Clarke?
4. Write the words in the brackets which in the passage mean :
 - (a) thought keeps coming again and again. ()
 - (b) different from what you expect. ()
 - (c) a narrow margin. ()
5. Which words describe Milkha Singh's feelings best? why?
 - (a) pain (b) anger (c) disappointment

(b) Poems

F. Read the poem given below :

An Irish Airman Foresees His Death

I know that I shall meet my fate
 Somewhere among the clouds above;
 Those that I fight I do not hate
 Those that I guard I do not love;
 My country is Kiltartan's poor.
 No likely end could bring them loss
 Or leave them happier than before,
 Nor law, nor duty bade me fight,
 Nor publicmen, nor cheering crowds,
 A lonely impulse of delight
 Drove to this tumult in the clouds;
 I balanced all, brought all to mind,
 The years to come seemed waste of breath,
 A waste of breath the years behind
 In balance with this life, this death.

W.B. Yeats

A. Now answer the following questions :

1. Which country does the airman belong?
2. Who does he hate?
3. 'Those that I guard I do not love'. Does this line mean;
 - (a) he hates the people he guards?
 - (b) he dislikes the people he guards?

- (c) he does not know the people enough to love them?
4. If he dies, will his country men's life be affected? Quote the lines that give you the answer.
 5. Why does the poet use 'waste of breath' twice?
 6. Does the poet like war? How do you know?
 7. Is the tone of the poem:
 - (a) cheerful ?
 - (b) sad ?
 - (c) encouraging ?

B. Read the poem given below and answer the questions :

The Road Not Taken

Two roads diverged in a yellow wood,
And sorry I could not travel both
And be one traveller, long I stood
And looked down one as far as I could
To where it bent in the undergrowth;

Then took the other, as just as fair,
And having perhaps the better claim,
Because it was grassy and wanted wear;
Though as for that the passing there
Had worn them really about the same,

And both that morning equally lay
In leaves no step had trodden black.
Oh, I kept the first for another day!
Yet knowing how way leads on to way,
I doubted if I should ever come back.

I shall be telling this with a sigh
Somewhere ages and ages hence:
Two roads diverged in a wood, and I-
I took the one less travelled by,
And that has made all the difference.

Robert Frost

Now answer the following questions:

1. Where did the two roads diverge?
2. Why did the poet choose the grassy road?
3. The phrase 'wanted wear' means:
 - (a) the road needs repair.
 - (b) the road was too difficult to travel on
 - (c) not many people travelled on that road
4. 'Yet knowing how way leads on to way' means _____
5. Was the poet certain that he would travel on that road some day? How do you know?
6. Choose the correct answer:

The poet uses the word 'road' to talk about _____ in life.

(a) meeting failures (b) taking decisions (c) facing distractions
7. The words *wood*, *stood* and *could* rhyme in the first stanza. Which last words rhyme in stanzas 2, 3 and 4?